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Self-Driving car research

Ford, the car manufacturer has teamed up with MIT and Stanford for research on the matter
<http://dgit.in/Selfdriven>

Feature



The launch of EV-DO Rev. B Phase II network, dubbed as 3GPLUS

data speeds of up to 9.8 Mbps. And now, the company is focusing its efforts on building its smartphone portfolio.

“Looking beyond regulatory issues, MTS also wants to fully leverage its 3GPLUS telecom network by further strengthening its Smartphone portfolio. We are already working with multiple handset partners and plan to bring out an exciting range of devices in 2014. In addition, our plans in the New Year include boosting our retail universe in order to get closer to our customers,” says the company in its outlook for 2014.

All is not as it appears though, and CDMA operators will have to fight tooth and nail to remain relevant. SSTL points out the difficulties that operators like MTS are facing: “While some would say that the dust has settled and there is more clarity within the telecom landscape in India; things are not the same with MTS, India’s only pure play CDMA operator. After having participated in the spectrum auctions in March 2013 and winning 3.75 MHz spectrum within the 800 Mhz band in 8 telecom circles, we were hopeful that things were finally looking up for us to implement our long-term strategies to drive data growth in the country. However, TRAI’s recommendations (in October 2013) on the next round of spectrum auctions completely neglected auctions for spectrum in the 800 MHz band thereby overlooking a possible growth path for CDMA operators like MTS.”

Pan-India Mobile Number Portability and free Roaming

Inter-circle mobile number portability and free roaming are among the key

elements in the National Telecom Policy (NTP) 2012. Citing burden of huge costs, operators have been reluctant to roll out these services and they remain to be limited to the home circle.

However, last year we saw operators such as Bharti Airtel and Idea Cellular making roaming charges partially free. This year, we can expect roaming charges to be completely removed.

Inter-circle number portability, however, may take some time to materialise. Though it favours the pan-India number portability, COAI (Cellular Operators Association of India) describes it as a complex matter. “We support the objectives of NTP-2012 and are committed to working with the Regulator and Department of Telecom on implementing these in a customer and industry friendly manner. National MNP is part of the NTP-2012 objectives and we look forward to working with the Department of Telecom, if they accept the TRAI recommendations,” Rajan S Mathews recently told Digit.

“National MNP is a very complex matter including over 10 operators, 2 MNP providers, several NLD (National Long Distance) and ILD (International Long Distance) players and 22 circles with over 900 million connections. Nowhere in the world has such a complex matter been done so far. So, all of the stakeholders are not ready as of now. We will need to commence the project design and implementation as soon as the Department of Telecom approves,” he added.

Integrated Operator Billing, Mobile Money and more

It’s really surprising that operators haven’t fully tapped the Integrated Operator Billing model. ‘Integrated operator billing’, also called ‘integrated carrier billing’ are billing services integrated within a mobile phone that allow the user to charge the costs of digital goods such as apps, music and movies to their phone bills. Back in 2012, Nokia tied up with Airtel and Vodafone to offer integrated billing on the Nokia Ovi Store. Surprisingly, we didn’t see other phone manufacturers follow suit.

Vodafone continued on its trailblazer path by recently launching ‘Vodafone Developer Platform’. The platform allows app developers and content providers, local and international, to build and sell apps through operator billing.

Mobile Money is expected to witness growth this year after the segment met a setback in March 2012 when Nokia shelved its mobile wallet, ‘Nokia Money’. However, Airtel has continued to push its ‘Airtel ICICI Bank Mobile Money’ service for mobile transactions. Another major operator, Vodafone launched its ‘m-Pesa’ service. Both, m-Pesa and Airtel ICICI Bank Mobile Money service will allow customers to make cash deposits, with-



Vodafone has its own Mobile Money service called ‘m-Pesa’

drawals and cash transfers to any mobile phone or bank account in India.

In 2014, telcos are likely to also focus on mobile banking given that many telcos have already initiated talks with various banks to provide m-banking services.

Data to drive the future

Data services, especially on the mobile platform, are expected to bring in plenty of business to the telecom space. For it to thrive, a higher mobile data services adoption rate is imperative. This will be made possible with the availability of compatible mobile devices, affordable data plans and rapidly rising Internet users in all circles.

In short, over the coming year, you can expect more bang for your buck with access to a range of content including high-end applications and services. Those in rural areas will have better Internet coverage and customised services such as m-healthcare, m-governance, m-banking, m-education, etc.